

A fine balance

Let's face it, the idea of talking openly about a sensitive topic – like the subject matter of our cover story – makes even the most accomplished badasses amongst us blush and squirm with embarrassment. For whatever reason, maturity is hard to come by when anything to do with love, relationships, and sex is being discussed. You'll find attempts at such conversations usually devolving into giggles, lewd humour, or complete reticence.

At Digit, we're always pushing your limits, and even with a topic this sensitive, we're going to push you harder than ever before. The rationale is, with the kind of unfiltered information overload we have in the world today, no one is really sequestered anymore; least of all Digit readers. Even if you haven't consciously thought about it, you kind of already know that technology is going to affect, or rather is affecting these areas in more ways than we thought possible. This is exactly the investigative approach our cover story aims to take. Is technology making it easier or harder to find true love? Can a machine know what is good for you? And ultimately, can a machine replace human companionship? These are just some of the questions we are trying to find answers to in this issue. What we figure is, since "Naughty Tech" is going to become mainstream (and commonplace) quite soon, you might as well know all about it now, and prepare yourself to...err... take it all in...

Despite our rationalisation, the topic of the cover story is going to raise a few eyebrows and I expect some amount of hate mail merely based on the fact that it's a sensitive topic. Much of the righteous indignation will erupt without even bothering to read our stories to find out how well (or badly) we've handled the topic. Of course, we can't resist the puns, but that's only to keep it light hearted because nothing breaks tension – sexual or otherwise – like humour. And as long as the cover story raises eyebrows and nothing else (as was the intent), I'm happy.

When I was growing up, access to technology wasn't a birthright the way it almost is today. The scraps of information we used to forage for back then, brought along a lot of misinformation. Is that true even today? While planning this cover story, or rather

when discussing its seemingly controversial nature, I had an interesting thought: if we decided against doing it, who are we really trying to protect? Readers like you or me don't need protecting. We, in fact, need to be enlightened, entertained and engaged in newer innovative ways. But there is a section that needs to be protected. I have a five-year old niece whose exposure to technology at this young age really scares me at times. She has almost unlimited access to her parents' phones. It is very possible for her to stumble across the dark alleyways of cyberspace quite accidentally.

A recent Norton survey reported that 40 percent of Indian parents allowed their children to access the internet before age 11. And while our broadcast ministry is on a rampage controlling what can be shown on television – a largely supervised form of entertainment in most homes – only 48 percent of parents allow internet access with supervision and only 37 percent review and approve all apps before they are downloaded.

While I'm all for freedom in all its forms, I feel that until these very young users are out of their most vulnerable stages, i.e., until they hit their late teens, parental control on the internet is a must. There are a ton of bad things that can happen from unrestricted access – cyber bullying, unwitting installation of malware, revealing too much personal information to strangers, and even learning things like hacking, which needs a thorough understanding of ethics before one can go mucking about in that sphere.

For what it's worth I'm not advocating a full lockdown. Far from it. I believe there is a fine balance between how much exposure those impressionable or vulnerable individuals should be allowed and how much unrestricted freedom should be given.

As always, I'm always open to debate and eagerly await your thoughts. 



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